

Comprehensive cat aggression handbook with evidence-based prevention and management strategies — Action Checklist

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CLASSIFY THE AGGRESSION TYPE

- ☐ **Classify Your Cat's Aggression Type:** Identify which of the six aggression categories your cat falls into—play, fear-based, petting-induced, territorial, redirected, or pain-related—since each requires a completely different intervention strategy.
- ☐ **Map Out the Predatory Sequence:** Track the stalking-pounce-bite pattern your cat follows before attacking so you can identify the precise moment to interrupt the behavior.
- ☐ **Rule Out Pain as the Root Cause:** Check for arthritis, dental disease, or injury if aggression has a sudden new onset, as pain-induced aggression requires medical treatment before behavior modification can work.
- ☐ **Recognize Stress Signals Before They Escalate:** Watch for flattened ears, dilated pupils, piloerection, and tail lashing as early warning signs that precede most attacks, allowing you to end interactions before biting occurs.

PREVENT ATTACKS PROACTIVELY

- ☐ **Redirect Predatory Energy Onto Appropriate Toys:** Use wand toys and teaser toys to channel your cat's hunting instincts away from your hands and feet, since play aggression responds best to redirecting the predatory sequence.
- ☐ **Give Your Cat Control Over Petting Sessions:** Let your cat initiate, determine the duration, and end the petting rather than forcing continued contact, since petting-induced aggression is about your cat asserting control.
- ☐ **Block Access to Redirected Aggression Triggers:** Close blinds or use window film to prevent your cat from seeing outdoor cats or wildlife that cause frustrated arousal, which often leads to redirected attacks on you.

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Never Punish an Attack: Avoid yelling, spraying water, or physical corrections after any aggressive episode, since punishment escalates fear-based aggression and makes the behavior problem significantly worse.

BUILD LONG-TERM BEHAVIOR CHANGE

- ☐ **Build Trust Through Predictable Positive Interactions:** Establish consistent daily routines and reward calm behavior with treats to reduce your cat's underlying anxiety, which drives fear-based and territorial aggression.
 - ☐ **Enrich the Environment to Meet Predatory Needs:** Install cat trees, puzzle feeders, and hiding spots so your cat can express natural stalking and hunting behaviors throughout the day, reducing pent-up frustration.
 - ☐ **Create a Written Behavior Modification Plan:** Document which triggers exist, when attacks occur, what interventions you try, and track progress weekly so you can adjust strategies based on what actually works.
 - ☐ **Involve Your Veterinarian or Behavior Professional:** Schedule a vet visit or contact a certified behaviorist if aggression causes injury, has sudden onset, or doesn't improve within several weeks of consistent management.
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Companion to the full guide in your Lemon Squeezy library — check off each item as you complete it.